

STAX Lab Assignment Email

Possible new project on school lunch modernization grants

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To: STAX Predoc Team <predocs@stax.example>
Date: Monday, March 4, 2024 at 8:17 AM
Attach: school_lunch_modernization_raw_data.zip

Hi team,

I have a possible new project that I would like to explore. The state has been giving small modernization grants to schools for cafeteria equipment, kitchen upgrades, and healthier meal infrastructure, but I do not yet have a clean sense of which schools received what.

The broad question is whether we can turn these grant records into an auditable school-year panel. My intuition is that better kitchens, cooler storage, salad bars, and serving-line upgrades may show up in meal participation or healthier menu measures, but I do not know what the raw files will support.

I attached the raw materials I have so far. They are not cleaned or documented beyond what is in the files, so please treat this as exploratory. I expect school and district names, grant records, equipment descriptions, and cafeteria partner role labels to be messy, and some judgment will be needed before we can say anything confidently.

Could you take a first pass and see whether it is possible to turn this into a school-year file for 2019-2024? I would like something that shows, for each school and year, whether the school received a modernization grant, roughly how much it received, what its lunch participation and healthy-meal measures look like, and whether it appears to have led a meal-program modernization effort.

Please do not worry about making this perfect on the first pass. I care more about a transparent, auditable workflow: what files are there, how names were matched, which role labels were counted as school meal-program leads, what looked ambiguous, and what should be checked before I rely on the results.

If an organization's role sounds like a district office, equipment vendor, food supplier, consultant, nutrition education group, or just a vague strategic partner, please flag it instead of automatically treating it as a school lead. A conservative first pass with clear caveats would be more useful than a polished file that hides the hard calls.

Thanks,

The Hon. Dr. Sir Jensen Ahokovi, PhD, MA, BA.

Professor of Accounting, Public Policy, and School Meals

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